

Telling your manager you made a mistake

10 findings · 15-step checklist · 1 myth · 6 sources · cheatgrid.com

Tell them yourself, before anyone else does. Owning a mistake outright lands better than it feels like it will, and **you'll judge it harder than your manager does.**

THE GOAL

You want your manager to hear this from you before you start managing how it looks. Write the one sentence that says what happened, then lead with it.

CHECKLIST

You've realized you made a mistake and you're about to tell your manager.

- ☐ Tell your manager yourself, before anyone else can, and pick a moment they can actually stop and focus.
- ☐ Write down **the one plain sentence** that says what happened, before you do anything else.
- ☐ Lead with **the sentence you wrote down**. Say it before any apology, explanation, or excuse.
- ☐ Name only what you actually know is affected, not what you're guessing might be.
- ☐ If you have a fix ready, **name it and give a timeline** for it.
- ☐ If you don't have a fix yet, say what you're doing right now and when you'll follow up.
- ☐ Give the one-line reason plainly, then move straight to what you're doing about it.
- ☐ Don't ask them to reassure you that it's fine.
- ☐ Say the apology once. Don't repeat it three different ways.
- ☐ **Let them respond** before you fill the silence with more explaining.
- ☐ If their reaction is sharp or cold, let it land without jumping in to defend yourself.
- ☐ If someone else is affected, be clear about who is telling them, you or your manager.
- ☐ Ask what they need from you right now, instead of assuming you already know.
- ☐ Thank them for hearing you out, then move the conversation to the fix.
- ☐ Write down what you'll check for next time, so this doesn't happen again.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** You judge your own admission more harshly than your manager usually will.
- 2** Own a genuine, honest mistake plainly, instead of downplaying or denying it happened.
- 3** Don't treat staying quiet as the safer move here. The best-performing teams are the ones whose people flag more problems early, while they're still small and easy to fix.

What you're afraid this makes you

KNOW

You judge your own admission more harshly than your manager usually will.

People consistently rated their own act of admitting a mistake more harshly than they rated the same act by someone else. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Telling them is worse in your head than it turns out to be. The dread outruns the moment.

People who actually went through with an apology felt far less stressed doing it than they did while dreading it beforehand. [Source 2](#)

DO

Own a genuine, honest mistake plainly, instead of downplaying or denying it happened.

This is a competence problem, and in the study, owning it beat denying it. [Source 3](#)

WATCH

Whether admitting this helps you or hurts you with this manager depends on your track record with them.

Someone already trusted often gets liked more for it, while someone still proving themselves can end up liked less. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

A single honest mistake doesn't get filed away as proof you can't be trusted to do the job.

People explain away a bad performance as a bad moment, not as proof you lack the skill. [Source 3](#)

What to actually say

SAY

Say it plainly: it was your fault, and you own it fully. Asking them to forgive you does far less work than that single sentence already did.

Acknowledging responsibility was rated the most convincing part of an apology, and asking to be forgiven the least. [Source 5](#)

SAY

Once you've owned it, say exactly what you'll do differently, instead of only apologizing.

Saying what you'll change works because nobody's stopped believing you're capable, just that this time didn't go well. [Source 3](#)

What it costs, and what's actually normal

KNOW

On average, even a well-handled mistake doesn't fully restore the trust you had before it, and that's a normal, common gap.

Even in that study's successful case, the trust measured afterward stayed below what it was before the mistake. [Source 3](#)

WATCH

A flat or muted reaction right after you tell them doesn't always mean it went badly. Receiving an apology is often a letdown too, for the person hearing it.

The other person often hoped this moment would feel better than it does, which has nothing to do with how well you handled it. [Source 2](#)

DON'T

Don't treat staying quiet as the safer move here. The best-performing teams are the ones whose people flag more problems early, while they're still small and easy to fix.

Teams whose people raise errors early fix those problems faster than teams whose people stay quiet. [Source 6](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

Explaining what happened will make it look like you're making an excuse, so leave the explanation out and just say you're sorry.

ACTUALLY

A short, honest reason for what happened is part of what makes an apology work, not the part that undermines it. The mistake is over-explaining, not giving a reason at all. [Source 5](#)

Sources

1. <https://www.bps.org.uk/research-digest/beautiful-mess-effect>
2. <https://www.jbs.cam.ac.uk/2014/the-art-of-apologising/>
3. <https://www.theglobeandmail.com/business/careers/management/article-before-apologizing-consider-whether-you-have-shown-lack-of-competence/>
4. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Pratfall_effect
5. <https://www.psychologicalscience.org/news/minds-business/effective-apologies-include-six-elements.html>
6. <https://www.uvu.edu/news/school-of-business/2025/building-high-performing-teams-psychological-safety.html>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Working with your manager at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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